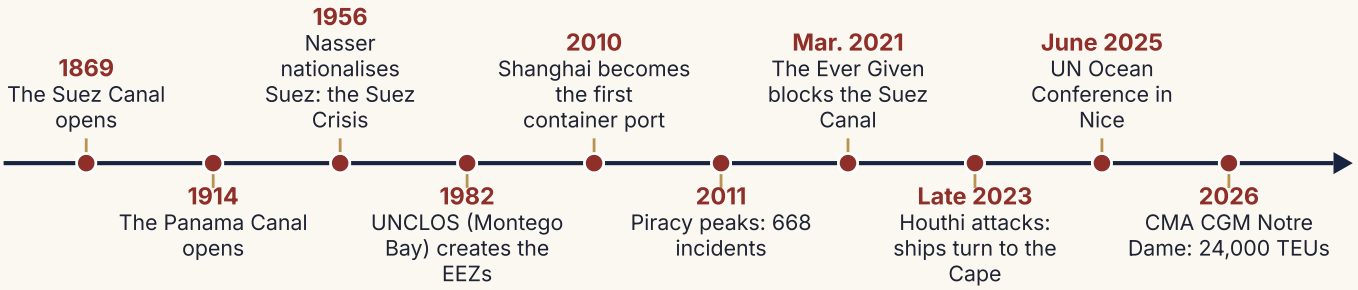
DNL HISTORY-GEOGRAPHY · TERMINALE BFI · M. ROS

G1 Maritimisation and the geostrategic importance of the seas

Theme 1 — Maritime Areas and Geopolitics at the Heart of a Globalised World

Objective. Assess how far maritimisation organises the global economy, and explain why maritime areas — EEZs, choke points, the high seas — have become strategic.

Ten dates to know



The big picture

Globalisation is maritime: 80% of world trade by volume travels by sea, in ever bigger container ships run by a handful of companies, between the ports of the three centres of the global economy — East Asia first. This maritimisation reshapes coasts, value chains and the division of labour; it also turns the sea into a reservoir of resources (fish, oil and gas, minerals, energy) and the bed of the Internet's cables. That is why the seas have become geostrategic: the law of the sea gives states EEZs, a few narrow choke points concentrate the world's flows and its risks, and the high seas raise the question of a common, sustainable governance.

KEY ISSUES

- Assess the main factors affecting maritime trade patterns.
- Evaluate the importance of maritimisation as a factor in the organisation of the global economy.

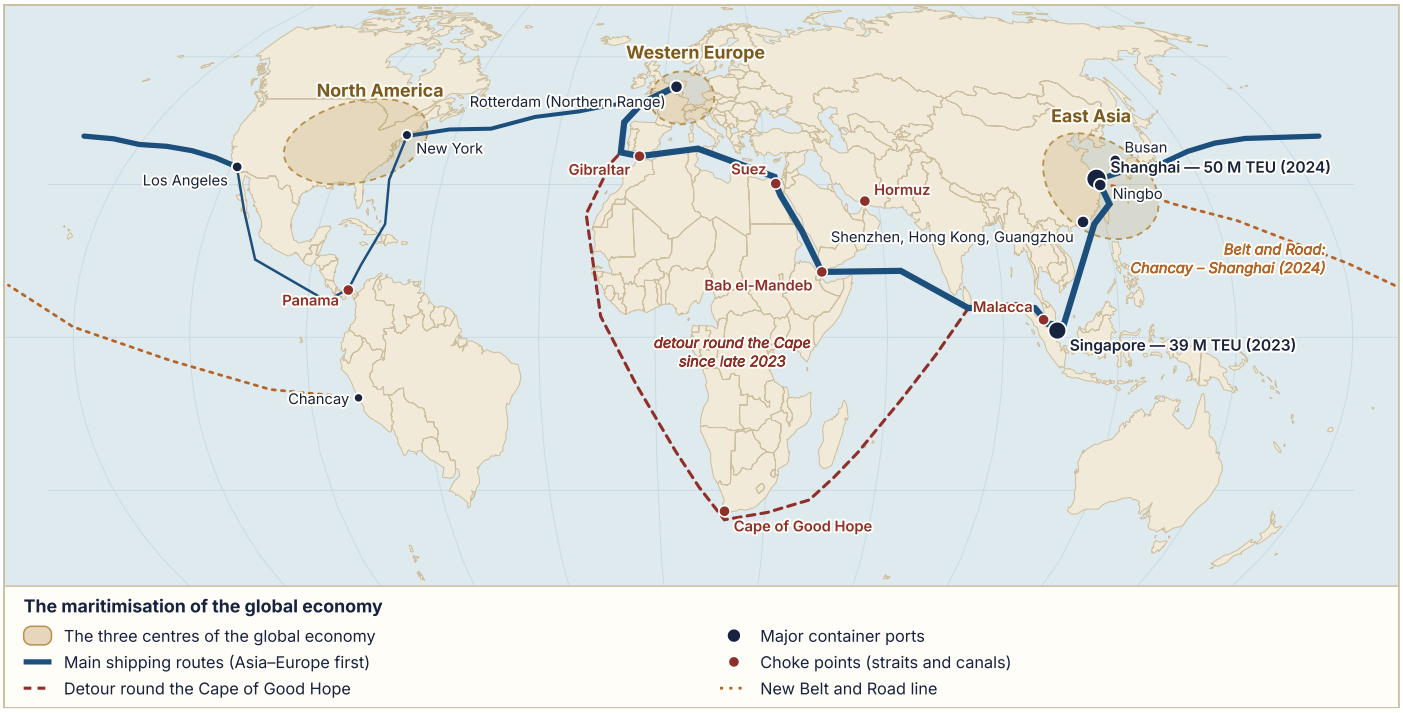
KEY TERMS

Globalisation · Containerisation · Maritime choke points · Exclusive Economic Zones (EEZs)

Summary diagram — How maritimisation organises the global economy — and makes it vulnerable

Containerisation — One standard box for ship, truck and train → **Gigantism** — 24,000-TEU ships; a few lines (MSC, Maersk, CMA CGM) → **Hubs and ports** — East Asia leads; ports move offshore → **Value chains** — TNCs produce near Asian ports: the NIDL → **Choke points** — Suez, Malacca, Hormuz: blockage, attacks, piracy → **Rules** — EEZs (1982), protected areas, high seas treaty

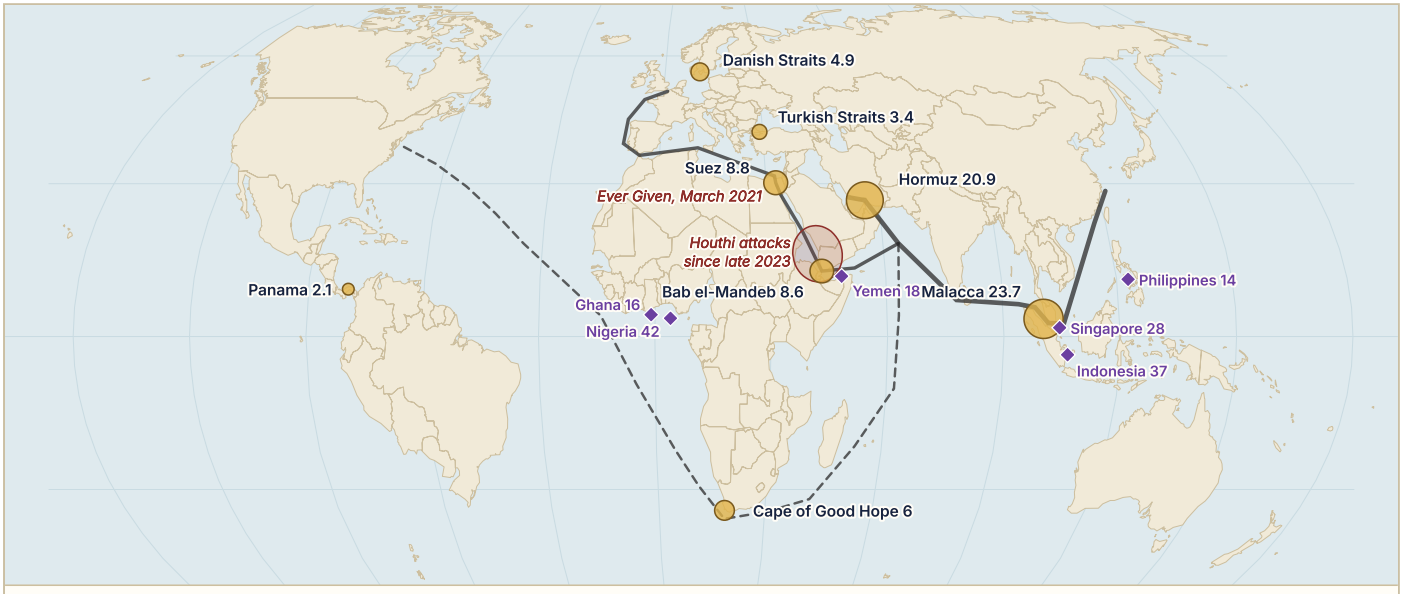
Summary map — The maritimisation of the global economy: centres, routes, ports, choke points



1. Shanghai: first container port since 2010, 50 million TEUs in 2024; Yangshan, offshore and automated.
2. Singapore: second container port, 39 million TEUs (2023), connected to more than 600 ports.
3. Rotterdam and the Northern Range: the first container region until the mid-1990s.
4. FAL 1 (CMA CGM): 105 days, 15 ships, 11 ports of call; to Europe via Suez, back round the Cape.
5. Suez (1869) and Panama (1914): Rotterdam–Singapore 8,440 nautical miles via Suez, 11,940 round the Cape.
6. Chancay (Peru, 2024): a port 60% owned by COSCO, on China's Belt and Road.

Natural Earth base map; routes simplified. The second map shows oil at the choke points and piracy.

Map — Oil and the choke points (2023), attacks and piracy



1. Malacca 23.7 and Hormuz 20.9 million barrels a day (2023); in 2025, Suez fell to 4.9 and the Cape rose to 9.1: the Houthi detour.
2. Malacca: more than 200 ships a day, 29% of seaborne oil, 25% of traded goods; 60% of China's oil.
3. Piracy: 668 incidents in 2011, 375 in 2020; Nigeria, Indonesia, Singapore first; in 2025 South-East Asia leads.

Volumes: U.S. Energy Information Administration; piracy: French Ministry of the Armed Forces and IMB.

Intro Globalisation: a maritime world

Globalisation is the growing interconnection of people, companies and governments

Globalisation is the process of increased interconnection among people, companies and governments worldwide. This new linkage creates competition between them. It is mainly due to improvements in transportation and communication, and to free trade; it resulted in a sped-up growth of international trade and cultural exchange (key term).

EXAMPLE "Maritime transport is the backbone of global trade and the global economy" (UN Secretary-General Ban Ki-moon, 29 September 2016): the quotation that opens the theme. The photograph that opens it is the port of Pasir Panjang in Singapore (27 December 2024), the second biggest container port in the world.

The seas are both the highway of globalisation and a geopolitical stake

The theme studies maritime areas in five steps: the maritimisation of the global economy (I), the geostrategic importance of maritime areas (II), the emergence of new shipping routes (III), geopolitical conflict in maritime zones (IV) and France as a great maritime power (V). This chapter covers parts I and II; chapter G2 covers parts III and IV, chapter G3 part V.

EXAMPLE · OUTSIDE THE COURSE Vietnam banned the film Barbie because one of its maps seemed to show China's "nine-dash line", Beijing's claim over most of the South China Sea: even a cartoon map at sea is political. (Year of the ban, 2023, added from outside the course.)

I.1 Maritimisation of the global economy: transportation and trade

Seaborne trade carries 80% of world trade by volume: there is no alternative

Shipping is the life blood of the global economy. Maritime transportation is dominant because there is no alternative for long-distance transportation of large amounts of freight. Since the 1960s, seaborne trade has increased enormously: it accounts for 80% of world trade by volume. Most goods are shipped on giant vessels connecting the three centres of the global economy: North America, Eastern Asia and Western Europe.

EXAMPLE Goods loaded worldwide rose from about 6 billion tons in 2000 to almost 12 billion in the early 2020s (UNCTAD), with two dips: the 2009 crisis and the Covid-19 pandemic of 2020. Course video: "A short history of the Maritime routes" (3 min), and a map of 18th-century British shipping routes drawn from ships' logs (James Cheshire).

A specialised fleet, in which bulk goods weigh most

The world fleet is specialised: container ships, oil tankers, chemical tankers, bulk carriers, liquefied natural gas (LNG) tankers, ro-ro ships (for vehicles) and general cargo ships. In tonnage, raw materials dominate: dry bulk (iron ore, grain, coal) and oil. The rise of the container ship is the great change since 1980.

EXAMPLE Shares of the world fleet capacity (UNCTAD, dead-weight tons): oil tankers 50% in 1980, 28% in 2024; dry bulk 27% then 43%; general cargo 17% then 4%; container ships a tiny share in 1980, 14% in 2024.

Containerisation: one standard box for every mode of transport

Containerisation is the increasing use of intermodal freight transport in standard-sized metal boxes (20 ft) which can be transferred from one mode of transport to another — ship, truck, train (key term). Capacity is counted in TEUs (twenty-foot equivalent units): the volume of one 20-ft box, 6.1 m long. The standard box made loading fast and cheap, and it is the base of today's global supply chains.

EXAMPLE · OUTSIDE THE COURSE The course video "A Brief History of Shipping: How a Steel Box Changed the World" (4 min) tells this story. The first container ship sailed in 1956 (the Ideal X of the American trucker Malcolm McLean); containers became widespread in the 1980s. (Added from outside the course.)

Gigantism: ever bigger ships on the Asia–Europe route

To cut the cost of each container, ships keep growing. The biggest container carriers carry about 24,000 TEUs and can only sail on the route between China and Europe, the only lane with enough ports able to handle them. On this route Asia, the main manufacturing region, ships manufactured goods, electronics and steel to Europe; Europe exports machinery, chemicals, pharmaceuticals, food and luxury goods to Asia, which is also a major market.

EXAMPLE The CMA CGM Notre Dame (2026): 24,000 TEUs, 399 m long, 61.3 m wide, powered by LNG, built in China by Yangzijiang Shipbuilding, the first of ten sister ships. Longer than four football fields or five Airbus A380s, bigger than the Empire State Building or the Eiffel Tower; a propeller more than 10 m across, an LNG tank that could hold the Statue of Liberty, an engine as powerful as 10 A380 jet engines; its containers would stretch for 141 km end to end (course video "Discover the Ship", 4 min). In the 2025 ranking, the ten biggest ship classes all carry 23,000 to 24,346 TEUs (MSC Irina).

A handful of shipping companies control container transport

Container shipping is concentrated in a few giant companies (an oligopoly), European and Asian. They order the giant ships and design the routes. CMA CGM is France's leading container shipping company: it was created in 1978, as a result of a series of mergers, by Jacques Saadé; his son Rodolphe Saadé, chairman and CEO, aims to make it the world's second-largest shipping line by 2027.

> **EXAMPLE** The ten largest container shipping companies in 2026 (TEU capacity, market share): MSC (Switzerland) 6.10 million, 20.1%; Maersk (Denmark) 4.28 million, 14.1%; CMA CGM (France) 3.87 million, 12.7%; COSCO Shipping (China) 3.36 million, 11.1%; then Hapag-Lloyd, ONE, Evergreen, HMM, Yang Ming and ZIM.

The great ports have moved to East Asia

About one container in ten handled worldwide is handled in the ports of the Yangtze River Delta. In East Asia, export-oriented industrialisation policies (Hong Kong, Taiwan, South Korea) sustained the growth of container throughput from the 1980s; China followed in the late 1980s, first in the Pearl River Delta, then in the Yangtze Delta (Shanghai). In the past ten years, Shanghai, Guangzhou, Shenzhen, Qingdao and Ningbo joined Hong Kong, Busan and Singapore as the world's major maritime hubs. Europe's Northern Range was the world's first container region until the mid-1990s, when south China took the lead.

> **EXAMPLE** Shanghai overtook Singapore in 2010 and became, in 2024, the first port in the world to handle 50 million TEUs in a year — the busiest container port for 15 consecutive years. Singapore, connected to more than 600 ports, handled 39 million TEUs in 2023. The 2018 map of the course ranks the container ports in million TEUs: Shanghai 42, Singapore 36.6, Ningbo 26.4, Shenzhen 25.7, Guangzhou 21.9, Busan 21.7, Hong Kong 19.6, Qingdao 19.3, Tianjin 16, Dubai 15 — the first European port, Rotterdam, is only 11th (14.5).

Ports link a hinterland to a foreland, and move offshore to receive the giants

A port connects the continental hinterland (production in factories) and the foreland (overseas markets). Coastal lands are transformed by the growth of seaborne traffic: new deep-water ports are built offshore to keep up with containerised trade. The rising concentration of people and activities on the coasts is the maritimisation of the world; this land use also contributes to environmental degradation.

> **EXAMPLE** Shanghai moved its port from the city centre to the estuary (Waigaoqiao), then offshore to the reclaimed islands of Yangshan, linked to the mainland by the Donghai Bridge, to receive ships with a draft of up to about 16 m. Yangshan is now an automated "smart port", partnered with 22 ports along the Yangtze, 16 of them in the Yangtze River Delta (Worksheet 3; course video on the automated wharf of Yangshan, 2025).

Container shipping reshaped global value chains and the division of labour

Seaborne trade connects global value chains: it carries raw materials and semi-processed goods to production hubs and delivers finished products to consumers. Container shipping allowed the global sourcing strategies of transnational corporations (TNCs) and the development of global production networks. It shaped the New International Division of Labour (NIDL): TNCs keep their offices and headquarters in the developed world and often have factories close to the ports of less developed countries, to take advantage of cheaper labour. It resulted in the maritimisation of economies.

> **EXAMPLE · OUTSIDE THE COURSE** Unilever, H&M and Apple: headquarters in the developed world, production in Asian factories near the ports. China discharges the most seaborne cargo (about 2.6 billion tons in 2023), Australia loads the most (about 1.5 billion tons) (UNCTAD, 2025). (Australia's main seaborne exports are iron ore and coal, much of them bound for China — added from outside the course.)

New routes follow the strategies of states: China's Belt and Road

Maritime trade patterns are also shaped by states. China, a "commercial thalassocracy" through the dominance of its port range, integrates its ports into the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) with new routes to foreign ports, to secure its supplies of raw materials and food.

> **EXAMPLE** The port of Chancay in Peru, 60% owned by the Chinese company COSCO, was inaugurated in the presence of Xi Jinping in November 2024. Direct lines to Shanghai and Ningbo-Zhoushan cut sailing times and costs by 20% compared with routes calling in Mexico; they bring iron ore from Peru, lithium from Bolivia, Chile and Argentina, and Peruvian fruit (Worksheet 3, Géoconfluences, 2025).

I.2 Marine resources

Fisheries feed millions of people, and aquaculture now outweighs wild capture

The fishing sector provides food for millions of people, but overfishing has become a concern: fish stocks are being depleted. Aquaculture (fish farms) is a solution to limit wild captures (capture fisheries). Asia dominates both. Some fishing methods, such as bottom trawling, damage the seabed.

> **EXAMPLE** World fisheries harvest in 2022: China 88.6 million tonnes, of which 75.4 million from aquaculture; Indonesia 22.0 million; India 15.8 million; Vietnam 8.8 million; Peru 5.5 million, almost all wild capture; Russia 5.3 million. Bottom trawling can destroy coral reefs and seabed life, raising sediment plumes visible from space; unwanted fish and marine life can make up 40 to 90% of the bycatch, thrown back into the sea (infographic of the course).

30% of the world's oil and gas comes from offshore fields, ever deeper

30% of world oil and gas production is extracted offshore, and exploration goes on to find new deposits. Production moves into deep water (more than 100 m), which is technically difficult and risky. Offshore fields help states reduce their dependence on imports.

> **EXAMPLE** In March 2025, the China National Offshore Oil Corporation (CNOOC) discovered a 100-million-ton oilfield, Huizhou 19-6, in China's EEZ in the South China Sea. The risk: the explosion of the Deepwater Horizon rig in the Gulf of Mexico on 20 April 2010 killed 11 workers and caused the largest accidental marine oil spill in the world (Worksheet 4). The main offshore zones on the map of Worksheet 4: the Gulf of Mexico, California, Venezuela, south-east Brazil, the Gulf of Guinea, the North Sea, the Caspian Sea and the Persian Gulf, with the Arctic as a potential resource.

The seabed holds minerals and sand, coveted for the green economy and for building

Humans have mined the ocean floor since the 1950s: diamonds, gold, gravel, then (from the 1960s) manganese nodules containing nickel, copper and cobalt. Deep-ocean polymetallic nodules, on the abyssal plains, also hold titanium and rare earth elements: the need for critical metals for high technology and the green-energy economy makes them a target. Sand is a strategic resource too. But dredging destroys marine habitats, and sand extraction causes severe coastal erosion.

> **EXAMPLE** Polymetallic nodules: "an improved understanding of the affected ecosystems … is required before operations begin" (James R. Hein et al., Nature, February 2020). Papua New Guinea is one of the few places where nodules lie in shallow waters (Worksheet 4).

Marine renewable energies are a potential to develop

The sea is also a source of renewable energy: ocean thermal energy (thermal energy conversion plants), offshore wind (fixed-foundation and floating turbines), tidal energy (tidal turbines) and wave energy (wave energy converters).

> **EXAMPLE** Offshore wind turbines stand between Sweden and Denmark, next to the cruise ships of the Baltic (Worksheet 4, document 1).

Marine resources are increasingly threatened by human activities

Marine resources are increasingly threatened or destroyed by human activities. The threats are climate change, marine pollution, the extraction of marine resources, and the destruction of marine and coastal habitats and landscapes. Exploiting the sea is therefore also a question of sustainability (see II.3).

> **EXAMPLE** Three threats from Worksheet 4: overfishing of wild stocks; dredging for nodules and diamonds, which wipes out fish and invertebrates; oil spills such as Deepwater Horizon (2010).

I.3 Communication and exchanges

The global Internet travels through vulnerable submarine cables

Underwater cables are the fastest and most cost-effective way to transport data across the ocean: the global Internet is made possible by them. They mostly lie on the ocean floor and are buried under the seabed near the shore for protection. They are vulnerable, and their routes avoid dangerous areas. Big tech companies are now the largest investors.

> **EXAMPLE** Meta plans a 50,000-km subsea cable, longer than the Earth's circumference, linking the United States, India, Brazil, South Africa and other regions, up to 7,000 m deep; it avoids the Red Sea, where Houthi rebels attack shipping, and the contested South China Sea. Meta and Google are the largest investors in new cables (ABC News, 19 February 2025).

Cruise tourism is one of the fastest-growing sectors

The sea is also a space of leisure. The cruise industry was badly hit by the Covid-19 pandemic in 2020; fuelled by heavy consumer demand and industry innovation, cruising rebounded faster than international tourism, and cruise capacity keeps growing.

> **EXAMPLE** Two million more people went on cruises in 2023 than in 2019, and demand was predicted to top 35 million passengers in 2024. Share of cruise passengers by region (CLIA, 2023): Caribbean, Bahamas and Bermuda 44.2%; Mediterranean 18.5%; rest of Europe 10.4%; Alaska 5.7%; west coast of North America 5.6%; Asia and China 4.6%. World cruise capacity is forecast to grow by at least 10% from 2024 to 2028.

The seas are also routes for migrants and refugees

Maritime areas carry people as well as goods: for refugees and migrants, the sea is a route — and a dangerous one. The Mediterranean, between Africa, the Middle East and the European Union, is crossed by several migration routes.

> **EXAMPLE** The main sea migration routes in the Mediterranean: the western route (Morocco and Algeria to Spain, through the Strait of Gibraltar), the central route (Libya and Tunisia to Italy and Malta), the eastern route (Turkey to Greece and Cyprus), fed by an East African route.

II.1 Geostrategic importance of maritime areas: exclusive economic zones

An EEZ gives a coastal state the resources of the sea up to 200 nautical miles

Exclusive Economic Zones (EEZs) are bands extending 200 nautical miles from the shore, in which the coastal government has jurisdiction over the exploration and exploitation of marine resources (key term). EEZs were created by the 1982 United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS), signed at Montego Bay (Jamaica). Since 1982, UNCLOS has guided sovereignty over waters: coastal countries have the sole rights to all resources of the waters and the seabed of their EEZ.

EXAMPLE France's EEZ covers about 10.7 million km², 62% of it in the Pacific thanks to its overseas territories (40% for French Polynesia alone): a small territory can command a huge sea. Course video: "What is the EEZ: the US case"; exercise of the course: write a simple definition of the EEZ in less than 15 words.

The law of the sea divides the ocean into zones, from full sovereignty to the high seas

UNCLOS distinguishes zones from the baseline (usually the low-water line): territorial waters (12 nautical miles), where sovereignty covers the airspace above and the seabed below; the contiguous zone, where a state controls customs, immigration and other laws; the EEZ (200 nautical miles), where it controls economic resources (fishing, mining, oil) but cannot forbid legal passage; a possible extension over the continental shelf; and beyond, the high seas — international waters, beyond any national jurisdiction.

EXAMPLE A container ship such as the CMA CGM Notre Dame sails freely through dozens of EEZs on its way from China to Europe, but a foreign trawler may not fish in them without permission.

When two EEZs collide, the line is drawn halfway — and disputes follow

When two EEZs overlap, UNCLOS calls for an equidistant line between the coasts, splitting the shared gulf or strait down the middle. EEZs are a stake of power for states: delimiting them can be a source of disputes, even between allies.

EXAMPLE UK–France fishing row, May 2021: two Royal Navy ships and two French vessels patrolled the waters off the British Channel Island of Jersey, as a dispute over post-Brexit fishing licences escalated: under the EU–UK trade deal, French boats had to show a history of fishing in the area to get a licence for Jersey's waters. France threatened to cut off Jersey's electricity, 90% of which comes through three undersea cables from France; the Royal Navy deployed the patrol boats HMS Severn and HMS Tamar.

Beyond the EEZs, the high seas escape almost every law

The high seas (international waters) lie beyond national jurisdiction: no state owns them. Freedom of navigation reigns, but control is weak — illegal fishing, abuses on board, pollution. This is why protecting the high seas has become a diplomatic issue (see II.3).

EXAMPLE Fadhil, a young deckhand, spent a year (2018–2019) on the Chinese squid-fishing ship Wei-Yu 18 in the South Atlantic and off Peru, far from any port; he died of beriberi, a disease of malnutrition, on 26 September 2019 and was buried at sea (video "Death on Chinese fishing ships in high seas"). Course video: "Who owns the high seas?" (5 min).

II.2 The maritime choke points

Choke points are narrow, crowded passages on which world trade depends

Maritime choke points are points of congestion on some of the world's famous shipping routes: narrow waterways with high traffic because of their strategic location (key term). They can be natural (straits) or man-made (canals). Should one of them be closed, world trade would be harshly affected: ships would have to take much longer routes.

EXAMPLE · OUTSIDE THE COURSE On 23 March 2021, the Ever Given, a container ship longer than the Eiffel Tower is tall, was wedged across the Suez Canal by heavy winds and blocked it completely for six days, paralysing trade between Asia and Europe. (Duration of the blockage added from outside the course.)

Canals: the Suez Canal, a short cut fought over since 1869

The Suez Canal, a 193-km man-made waterway through Egypt, links the Mediterranean to the Red Sea, and so the Atlantic to the Indian Ocean. Opened in 1869, it is the longest canal in the world without locks (13–15 hours to cross), so it can even take aircraft carriers. About 12% of world trade passes through it each year: without it, a supertanker from the Gulf to Europe would sail 6,000 extra miles around Africa's Cape of Good Hope. The Panama Canal, opened in 1914 — 45 years later — and much shorter, links the Pacific and the Atlantic.

EXAMPLE 1.03 billion tons of cargo crossed the canal in 2019, four times more than the Panama Canal. Nasser nationalised it in 1956, which sparked the Suez Crisis and closed it for a year; the 1967 war closed it for eight years. It earned Egypt about $10 billion in 2023; the expansion completed in 2015 doubled its revenue (Worksheet 5). What the canals save, in nautical miles (course map, J.-P. Rodrigue): Rotterdam–Singapore 8,440 via Suez against 11,940 round the Cape; Rotterdam–Mumbai 6,374 against 10,667; New York–Los Angeles 4,970 via Panama against 12,350 through the Strait of Magellan; Rotterdam–Los Angeles 7,836 against 13,522; New York–Sydney 9,332 against 12,000.

Straits: the Strait of Malacca, the busiest passage between two oceans

The Strait of Malacca is the shortest shipping channel between the Indian Ocean and the Pacific, linking the Middle East to China, Japan and South Korea. It is a choke point on several scales: world (one third of world trade), regional (East Asia) and national (China's oil). China calls this dependence its main geopolitical choke-point challenge.

> **EXAMPLE** More than 200 vessels a day pass through the strait, carrying 29% of all oil transported by sea and 25% of the world's traded goods. China and Japan rely on it for 80% of their oil imports; about 60% of China's entire oil supply passes through this stretch, one and a half miles wide at its narrowest. The strait is about 940 km long and 3 km wide; vessel transits rose from 55,957 in 2000 to 84,456 in 2017. At its southern end, Singapore is the second container port in the world (33.67 million TEUs), ahead of Port Klang (13th, 11.98 million) and Tanjung Pelepas (19th, 8.38 million) (Worksheet 6, Alphaliner, 2018). Course video: "Why is the Strait of Malacca so Important to the World's Economy & Military" (8 min).

Oil flows through a few choke points: Malacca and Hormuz first

Oil, the first good traded by sea, depends on a few passages. The Strait of Hormuz, the exit of the Persian Gulf, is the most sensitive: about a fifth of the world's oil passes through it every day, and Iran threatens from time to time to close it — in 2023, if the United States directly aided Israel in its war with Hamas, or tightened sanctions on Iran. The strait is watched by the naval bases of Iran's Revolutionary Guards and by the US 5th Fleet, based in Bahrain.

> **EXAMPLE** Daily transit of petroleum in 2023 (U.S. Energy Information Administration, million barrels a day): Strait of Malacca 23.7; Strait of Hormuz 20.9; Suez Canal 8.8; Bab el-Mandeb 8.6; Cape of Good Hope 6; Danish Straits 4.9; Turkish Straits 3.4; Panama Canal 2.1. In 2023, 20.5 million barrels of oil and products passed through Hormuz each day on average (Graphic News). In 2025 (Worksheet 6): Malacca 23.2; Hormuz 20.9; Cape of Good Hope 9.1; Suez Canal 4.9; Danish Straits 4.9; Bab el-Mandeb 4.2; Turkish Straits 3.7; Panama Canal 2.3. Between 2023 and 2025, Suez and Bab el-Mandeb lost about half their oil while the Cape gained half as much again: the Houthi detour, in figures.

Choke points are exposed to wars and attacks, which redraw routes

Because they are narrow, choke points are where conflicts hit trade. Strategic straits attract military bases, piracy and migration, and a crisis can divert the world's ships for years. Shipping companies then choose between risk and cost.

> **EXAMPLE** After the Houthi rebels of Yemen began attacking merchant ships near Bab el-Mandeb in late 2023, the Suez route was largely abandoned for the Cape of Good Hope. CMA CGM led the return to Suez, then, in January 2026, sent three services (FAL 1, FAL 3, MEX) back round the Cape "in light of the complex and uncertain international context" (Worksheet 1). Djibouti, at the mouth of the Red Sea, hosts foreign military bases. Course videos on two strategic straits: Djibouti (12 min) and Gibraltar (35 min) — world trade, strategic location, military bases, piracy, and migration at Gibraltar.

Choke points cause tension, but they also force cooperation

User states and neighbouring states do not see a strait in the same way. Users (China, Japan, the USA…) see a strategic axis of the world economy and care about free movement and the safety of their ships (piracy, terrorism). Neighbouring states see an inland sea, fragile, where populations living off the sea are concentrated; they fear that external military powers interfere on the pretext of security, as happened off Somalia. Securing the strait therefore requires cooperation.

> **EXAMPLE** Malaysia, Indonesia and Singapore share the Strait of Malacca and its problems (piracy, pollution, the haze from forest fires). In a war between the USA and China, control of the strait would be vital; China looks for alternatives, but a canal through Thailand's Isthmus of Kra will likely not be dug, because of its disastrous ecological effects (Worksheet 6).

Piracy threatens shipping near a few coasts

Piracy and armed robbery at sea threaten ships near certain coasts and straits: the Gulf of Guinea, South-East Asia (Indonesia, Singapore, the Philippines) and the Gulf of Aden. Incidents have fallen since their 2011 peak, thanks in part to naval patrols, but they remain numerous.

> **EXAMPLE** Piracy and robbery incidents (French Ministry of the Armed Forces): 439 in 2008, a peak of 668 in 2011, then about 360 to 380 a year from 2016 to 2020 (375 in 2020). Countries with the most incidents: Nigeria 42, Indonesia 37, Singapore 28, Yemen 18, Ghana 16, the Philippines 14, Benin 13, India 11, Saint Vincent and the Grenadines 11, Peru 10. In 2025 (International Maritime Bureau, Worksheet 6), South-East Asia leads by far — about 90 incidents (the figure is blurred on the worksheet: 85 or 95) — ahead of the Gulf of Guinea (21), the Indian subcontinent (8), off Somalia (8) and the Americas (5).

II.3 The challenge of sustainability

Shipping pollutes, but less per tonne carried than any other transport

The shipping industry accounts for 3% of greenhouse-gas emissions. Sea transport has become more fuel efficient, safer and cheaper, but sustainability can still improve: minimise pollution in ports, for workers and residents; make oil tankers safer to avoid oil spills; develop new green fuels (green methanol, hydrogen); recycle ships. Yet shipping emits far less CO_2 per kg transported than any other means of transport.

> **EXAMPLE** The container ship MV X-Press Pearl caught fire and sank off Colombo, Sri Lanka, in June 2021, spilling chemicals and plastic pellets on the coast. The CMA CGM Notre Dame (2026) runs on liquefied natural gas, less polluting than heavy fuel oil.

Marine protected areas are growing, far from the 30% target

Marine protected areas (MPAs) limit human activities to preserve biodiversity. The COP15 biodiversity conference in Montreal (2022) set the target of protecting 30% of the ocean by 2030. Coverage is growing, but slowly, and protection is often weak: bottom trawling is still allowed in many MPAs.

> **EXAMPLE** The announcements of the UN Ocean Conference in Nice (June 2025) raised global MPA coverage from 8.4% to about 11%, according to French estimates; environmental groups criticised France for offering little immediate restriction on bottom trawling (Worksheet 8, Le Monde).

The high seas treaty: governing the ocean beyond national jurisdiction

Because the high seas belong to no one, states negotiate to protect them. The BBNJ agreement (Biodiversity Beyond National Jurisdiction), or "high seas treaty", adopted in 2023, allows marine protected areas outside the EEZs; it needed 60 ratifications to come into force. The other battle is deep-sea mining: some states want a moratorium, others want to start extracting.

> **EXAMPLE · OUTSIDE THE COURSE** At the third UN Ocean Conference (Nice, June 2025: 60 heads of state and government, without the United States), 50 countries had ratified the treaty and about 15 more pledged to; 37 countries called for a moratorium on deep-sea mining, France's position since 2022, while Donald Trump had ordered in April 2025 faster permits to mine in international waters. The treaty reached 60 ratifications in September 2025 and came into force in January 2026. (Added from outside the course.)

Bac At the exam: the 2025 essay on maritimisation (Worksheet 7)

The June 2025 question asked you to weigh maritimisation against the other factors

In June 2025, the geography essay of subject B asked: "Maritimisation is the most important factor in the organisation of the global economy." Assess the validity of this statement. To assess is to weigh: first show how maritimisation organises the global economy (seaborne trade, containerisation, ports, choke points, resources, cables), then confront it with other factors (TNCs and global value chains, states' policies and the law of the sea, finance, air and land transport, digital networks), and give a clear judgement.

> **EXAMPLE** Worksheet 7 gives two real anonymised scripts of this exam to assess (copies 2-040 and 2-048). The site's reading of them is below: it is not M. Ros's marking.

Key figures

Ban Ki-moon
UN Secretary-General: "maritime transport is the backbone of global trade" (2016)

Jacques Saadé
Founder of CMA CGM (1978), France's leading container shipping company

Rodolphe Saadé
Chairman and CEO of CMA CGM, who wants it to be the world's second shipping line by 2027

Gamal Abdel Nasser
Egyptian president who nationalised the Suez Canal in 1956

Xi Jinping
Chinese president, at the inauguration of the Chinese-owned port of Chancay (Peru, 2024)

Nathalie Fau
Geographer: users and neighbours do not see the Strait of Malacca the same way

Numbers

80%
Share of world trade (by volume) carried by sea

24,000 TEUs
Capacity of the CMA CGM Notre Dame (2026), 399 m long

1 in 10
Containers of the world handled in the Yangtze River Delta

50 million TEUs
Shanghai's throughput in 2024, a world first

30%
Share of world oil and gas produced offshore

200 nautical miles
Width of an EEZ (UNCLOS, 1982)

12%
Share of world trade through the Suez Canal

29% / 25%
Shares of seaborne oil and of traded goods through the Strait of Malacca

23.7 / 20.9
Million barrels of oil a day through Malacca and Hormuz (2023)

3%
Shipping's share of greenhouse-gas emissions

30% by 2030
Target for protecting the ocean (COP15, 2022); about 11% in 2025

Vocabulary

TRADE AND TRANSPORT

Globalisation
Growing interconnection of people, companies and governments worldwide (key term).

Maritimisation
The growing role of the sea in the economy, and the concentration of people and activities on coasts.

Containerisation
Use of standard metal boxes moved from ship to truck to train (key term).

TEU
Twenty-foot equivalent unit: the measure of a container ship's capacity.

Gigantism
The race to ever bigger ships to cut the cost of each container.

Hub
Major port where cargo is concentrated and transhipped between lines.

Hinterland / foreland
The land area a port serves / the overseas markets it connects to.

Global value chain
Production split into stages located in different countries.

NIDL
New International Division of Labour: headquarters in the North, factories near ports in the South.

Thalassocracy
A power whose strength rests on the sea (said of China's port range).

RESOURCES

Capture fisheries / aquaculture
Wild fishing / fish farming.

Overfishing
Fishing faster than stocks can renew themselves.

Bottom trawling
Dragging a net along the seabed, which destroys it.

Offshore
At sea: offshore oil and gas fields, offshore wind farms.

Polymetallic nodules
Lumps on the deep seabed rich in nickel, cobalt, copper and rare earths.

Marine renewable energies
Offshore wind, tidal, wave and ocean thermal energy.

THE LAW OF THE SEA AND CHOKE POINTS

UNCLOS
UN Convention on the Law of the Sea (1982).

Territorial waters
12 nautical miles of full sovereignty.

Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ)
200 nautical miles where the coastal state controls resources (key term).

High seas
International waters, beyond national jurisdiction.

Maritime choke point
Narrow, crowded strait or canal on a major route (key term).

Strait / canal
Natural / man-made passage between two seas.

Piracy
Attacks and robbery against ships at sea.

Marine protected area (MPA)
Sea area where human activities are limited to protect biodiversity.

BBNJ
The high seas treaty (2023): biodiversity beyond national jurisdiction.